Risk and Adaptivity in Certifying Machine-Learning Model Comparisons

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Abstract

Background. Auditing a machine-learning model can require retrieving missing verification targets. The auditor must choose between a full export, a fixed batch of measurements and queries that depend on earlier answers. These choices can have different guarantees even with the same reading budget.

Methods. We study the sharp interval containing a model-loss contrast over all records consistent with the available information. The contrast is affine, the uncertainty set compact and convex, and the query dictionary finite and linear. We classify terminal-width penalties and give exact two-query algorithms with independently checkable certificates.

Results. Randomized batch and adaptive minimax risks agree for every such problem if and only if the nondecreasing penalty is concave. Constructed families have identical optimal expected widths but sharply different precision guarantees. In 290 of 4,914 frozen forecast comparisons, two adaptive counter readings guarantee halving the initial width, whereas optimal randomized-batch worst-case success is 50%. An external source reproduces this gap in 29 of 1,674 comparisons. Overall recorded gains over the best deterministic worst-width batch are 0.407 and 0.119 percentage points. Under illustrative 1% internal-reading errors with exact endpoints, all 29 external cases remain certifiable using two readings in 22 cases and three in seven. Capacity bounds often remove feedback necessity, and measured public-API retrieval favors bulk.

Conclusions. The method identifies which acquisition protocol meets a declared assurance requirement. An executable selector chooses among supplied certified protocols using declared measurement assumptions and resource limits.

Keywords: artificial intelligence; machine learning; adaptive information; minimax risk; optimal recovery; robust optimization.

1 Introduction

A model audit may need additional measurements before it can justify a comparison. The auditor can retrieve the full record, choose a batch of readings in advance, or choose later readings after seeing earlier answers. We call the last option adaptive querying. A sharp interval is the smallest interval containing the loss difference for every record compatible with the available information. This paper asks when feedback improves the guarantee that this interval will be sufficiently narrow.

A narrow interval can still contain zero, so precision and identifying the better model are separate goals.

We study affine scalar contrasts on nonempty compact convex uncertainty sets, with queries selected from a fixed finite dictionary of linear measurements. This formulation includes paired squared-loss comparisons, overlapping linear constraints, valid coordinate bounds, signed targets, and fixed query costs. Batch and adaptive policies have the same hard budget. The unknown record is fixed before the algorithm's random seed is drawn; probabilities describe acquisition randomization, not a distribution assumed for the missing truth. Fixed bounded measurement errors can be included by enlarging the hidden record when the resulting uncertainty set is compact and convex.

The computer-science question is how an acquisition algorithm should use feedback when its output must be valid for every compatible record. We ask which risk objectives permit a feedback advantage, how to compute an instance-specific guarantee, and which permitted retrieval protocol should implement it. The fitted forecasting models supply fixed prediction vectors; the proposed algorithm governs their verification data, rather than learning a new predictor.

The contribution is a classification of when feedback can change minimax certificate risk, sharp realizations using admissible information queries, and an exact two-query decision rule with checkable precision guarantees. Concavity exactly characterizes the nondecreasing width penalties for which adaptation never improves randomized minimax risk. A coordinate-query construction proves the converse, and a family separates equal mean-width optima from success probabilities $1/K$ and one. The classification uses established minimax reasoning and Jensen's inequality. A dimension-dependent precision consequence adapts established sparse-policy bounds (Kurtz, 2026); we do not claim a new general sparsification theorem.

Cumulative meter records test whether this distinction affects actual forecast comparisons. Before optional answers are revealed, the two-query rule identifies cases where a fixed batch suffices, feedback changes feasibility, or two queries do not provide a deterministic guarantee. The original and external studies contain 290 of 4,914 and 29 of 1,674 cases, respectively, with an exact adaptive-versus-batch precision-success gap of one versus one half. These cases span three meters and six model pairs in each source. The large worst-case assurance gap is distinct from the small overall recorded gains of 0.407 and 0.119 percentage points.

The acquisition interface determines which guarantee is useful. Under the declared 1% internal-reading error allowance and exact endpoints, all 29 selected external cases remain certifiable: 22 use two readings and seven use three. Added capacity information can remove the need for feedback. On the measured public API, bulk retrieval is preferable. Our implementation therefore chooses among supplied certificates using the permitted measurements, reading and round limits, and cost priority. It reports when those certificates cannot meet the declared requirements.

The paper develops the classification and sharp examples, then computable two-query guarantees and their cumulative-meter specialization. The evaluation reports fixed protocols, recorded replay, uncertainty sensitivity and actual retrieval measurements. Online Resource 1 provides extended proofs, the separate compact coordinate-query solver, historical controls, complete case ledgers and executable verification.

1.1 Related work and the contribution boundary

Partial identification studies conclusions that survive incomplete observations (Manski, 2005; Maia Polo et al., 2024). For model comparison, cancellation in paired squared losses leaves an affine function of the unknown truth; this is established loss structure rather than a new loss function (Patton, 2011). Active evaluation and model selection acquire labels for estimating performance or

choosing among predictors (Sawade et al., 2012; Hara et al., 2024; Kossen et al., 2021; Okanovic et al., 2025). Our target is the entire sharp interval of a fixed-record contrast after exact observations. No estimator of the population risk, surrogate label distribution, or new forecasting architecture is introduced.

The certificate width is the established local diameter of information (Novak and Woźniakowski, 2008, Section 4.1). Osipenko (2019, Theorems 2–3 and 5) also studies when adaptation cannot improve noisy scalar recovery. Those criteria concern deterministic reconstruction error and the existence of an optimal nonadaptive linear reconstruction; the present criterion instead classifies randomized penalties of the complete terminal information-fiber width. Classical deterministic results already establish strong limits on adaptivity: on convex symmetric classes with linear information, Novak and Woźniakowski (2008, Theorem 4.4) construct nonadaptive information with no greater global diameter and at most twice the reconstruction radius. For scalar targets the radius comparison is exact (Novak and Woźniakowski, 2008, Theorem 4.5). A modern formulation of the factor-two bound appears in Krieg et al. (2025, Proposition 4.1). Nonsymmetric convex uncertainty itself is also established: Novak (1995) compares adaptive and nonadaptive optimal-recovery errors using relations between Gelfand and Bernstein widths. The classical objective is reconstruction error, whereas our randomized penalty applies to the full terminal compatible interval. Our classification allows nonsymmetric convex sets and concerns randomized penalties of the terminal local diameter, including a converse and exact precision and moment separations. Its mean-risk interchange applies Sion (1958, Theorem 3.4); the concave-penalty upper bound uses Jensen's inequality.

For fixed deterministic scalar information, the optimal worst-case reconstruction error is half the largest fiber width. The distinction here concerns randomized local-width penalties and the order of averaging and worst-case evaluation. Specifically, Krieg et al. (2025, Section 2) and Krieg and Ullrich (2026, Section 9.1, Eq. (9.15), author manuscript v2) study $\inf_A \sup_{y\in F} \mathbb{E}_\omega \|T(y) - A_\omega(y)\|$, the error of a selected reconstruction. Here the random transcript instead incurs the full compatible-interval width $W_{Q_\omega(y)}(y)$. Writing its scalar local radius as $r_{Q_\omega(y)}(y) = W_{Q_\omega(y)}(y)/2$, our mean risk is $2\sup_y \mathbb{E}_\omega r_{Q_\omega(y)}(y)$. For a randomized batch, this generally differs from $2\mathbb{E}_\omega \sup_y r_{Q_\omega}(y)$, twice the expected global radius discussed in Krieg and Ullrich (2026, Eq. (2.4), Remark 6.1 and Section 6.1, author manuscript v2). The midpoint reconstruction has pointwise error at most the local radius, but its error at the actual record need not equal that radius. Consequently, neither replacing actual reconstruction error by interval width nor interchanging the expectation and supremum preserves the optimization problem. The present theorem concerns the terminal local-width risk. The fixed measurement dictionary is substantive: if every linear functional were directly queryable at the same cost, a scalar affine target could be determined by querying its linear part once.

Information-dependent decisions are also established in adjustable robust optimization (Wei and Zhang, 2024; Vayanos et al., 2026). The dimension-dependent precision bound below adapts the sufficient-policy result of Kurtz (2026, Theorem 2 and Example 5); its query interpretation and sharp examples are made explicit. Weighted-oracle randomized optimization and dynamic-program LP constructions are established (Kawase and Sumita, 2024; Martin et al., 1990). The supporting aggregate solver contributes a structured hard-budget batch representation and dual-completion certificate (Online Resource 1, S5/S7). Secondary optimization among tied robust solutions follows an established concern (Iancu and Trichakis, 2014).

Adaptive sampling of cumulative information has close precedents. Gaillard et al. (2023, Section 4.1.1, Corollary 1 and Theorem 3) study certified scalar integral estimation from sequential evaluations of a monotone function. For monotone contrast coefficients, summation by parts relates the register problem to weighted monotone integration. Our instance test pairs an adaptive precision guarantee with an adverse distribution limiting every randomized batch under the same

information interface.

Kuboyama (2026, Theorem 1 and Proposition 1) gives exact model-choice certificates after adaptive binary labels and compares shared-label paired bounds with separate intervals. That work also distinguishes hindsight certificate size from acquisition requirements (Theorem 2 and Proposition 3). Our application uses constrained continuous targets, while the central classification concerns the penalty of terminal sharp width. These precise distinctions, rather than certification or shared comparisons generally, define the contribution relative to model-choice and information-discovery frameworks.

2 Methods

2.1 Model Comparisons and Sharp Information

Let $a, b \in \mathbb{R}^N$ be two fixed prediction vectors for the same scheduled targets. Their paired mean-squared-error difference is

$$D(y) = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\{(a_i - y_i)^2 - (b_i - y_i)^2\} = d + c^\top y, \qquad c_i = \frac{2(b_i - a_i)}{N}. \tag{1}$$

All scheduled targets remain in the denominator. Initially observed values, documented aggregate measurements and other defensible constraints define the feasible set F. Any permitted archive record that directly reconstructs a target is incorporated before this set is declared. Sharpness is always relative to that declared information set.

The attainable interval of D on F is an identification interval for this record, not a sampling confidence interval. A negative upper endpoint certifies that a has smaller squared loss for every completion; a positive lower endpoint certifies b. An interval containing zero cannot certify a strict winner. Subsequent exact measurements restrict F to a fiber and therefore cannot widen its sharp interval. A prescribed width threshold instead asks for a precision guarantee, regardless of the interval's location.

The mathematical examples below also describe paired squared-loss widths. Given any contrast coefficient c, nonnegative predictions $a_i = N\max(-c_i, 0)/2$ and $b_i = N\max(c_i, 0)/2$ realize that coefficient in (1). The induced constant changes the interval's position, but not its width. Thus the constructions have a model-comparison interpretation without being measurements of prediction performance.

2.2 Information, terminal width, and risk

Let $F \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ be nonempty, compact, and convex, and let $T(y) = c^\top y + d$ be the scalar quantity to be audited. A fixed finite collection of exact linear measurements is available. Write L_Q for the measurement matrix of a selected set Q, and let $\mathcal{Q}$ be the nonempty finite family of admissible final sets, available to both policy classes. Admissibility is determined before observing answers; for example, $\sum_{j\in Q} k_j \le B$ for nonnegative fixed costs k_j. Coordinate observations correspond to rows of the identity matrix. The results do not require nonnegative targets or disjoint aggregates.

For a feasible record y, define the information fiber and its sharp target width by

$$F_Q(y) = \{z \in F : L_Q z = L_Q y\}, \qquad W_Q(y) = \max_{z\in F_Q(y)} T(z) - \min_{z\in F_Q(y)} T(z). \tag{2}$$

The extrema exist by compactness, and $0 \le W_Q(y) \le D_T$, where $D_T = \max_F T - \min_F T$. This is the local diameter of the scalar information fiber. The optimized quantity is the full fiber's diameter, rather than the actual error of a selected point estimate; it is not a confidence interval. An additive constant in T does not affect W_Q. In particular, a paired squared-loss contrast is affine in the unknown verification targets and fits this formulation.

A randomized batch policy draws $Q \sim \pi$ before seeing answers. An adaptive policy selects successive measurements and a stopping decision from the answers already observed and an independent internal random seed. Every execution must terminate after finitely many queries at a set in $\mathcal{Q}$. Query and stopping rules are jointly measurable in the observed history and seed; observations are exact. For a finite-valued, nondecreasing function $\phi : [0, \infty) \to \mathbb{R}$, define

$$R^{\phi}_{\text{batch}} = \inf_{\pi \in \Delta(\mathcal{Q})} \sup_{y \in F} \mathbb{E}_{Q \sim \pi} \phi(W_Q(y)), \qquad R^{\phi}_{\text{adaptive}} = \inf_{\mathcal{P}} \sup_{y \in F} \mathbb{E}\phi(W_{Q_{\mathcal{P}}(y)}(y)). \tag{3}$$

The hidden record is fixed before the random seed is drawn. Thus the supremum is outside the expectation. When measurement error is represented by additional hidden coordinates, one fixed error vector is part of that record for the entire execution. An adversary choosing a new error after each query is a different information model. These objectives concern terminal width under a hard budget, rather than expected requests until a winner is certified. The expectations are well defined: the widths are Borel measurable by Proposition 1, and a finite-valued monotone ϕ is Borel measurable and bounded on $[0, D_T]$.

For a required precision $\tau \ge 0$, let $\mathcal{C}$ be either the randomized batch or randomized adaptive policy class, and write $Q_{\mathcal{P}}(y, \omega)$ for the terminal set under internal seed ω. Define its optimal worst-case precision-success probability by

$$\begin{aligned} S^{\mathcal{C}}_{\tau} &= \sup_{\mathcal{P} \in \mathcal{C}} \inf_{y \in F} \Pr_{\omega} \big\{ W_{Q_{\mathcal{P}}(y,\omega)}(y) \le \tau \big\} \\ &= 1 - R^{\phi_\tau}_{\mathcal{C}}, \qquad \phi_\tau(w) = \mathbf{1}\{w > \tau\}, \end{aligned} \tag{4}$$

where $R^{\phi_\tau}_{\mathcal{C}}$ denotes the corresponding risk in (3). The identity follows by complementing the success event and reversing each supremum or infimum under subtraction from one; it does not require an optimal policy to attain either bound. The probability concerns the algorithm's seed at a fixed hidden record, and equality at the threshold counts as success. Reaching this precision does not require the interval to exclude zero, so it need not certify a winning model.

Proposition 1 (Concavity and the transcript fiber)**.** *For every fixed Q, W_Q is nonnegative, finite, concave, and upper semicontinuous on F. For every adaptive execution, its terminal information fiber is precisely $F_Q(y)$ for its terminal queried set Q.*

Proof. Choose maximizing and minimizing endpoints $u_k, v_k \in F_Q(y_k)$, $k = 1, 2$. For $0 \le \lambda \le 1$, convexity of F and linearity of the measurements make $\lambda u_1 + (1-\lambda)u_2$ and $\lambda v_1 + (1-\lambda)v_2$ feasible endpoints at $\lambda y_1 + (1-\lambda)y_2$. Their target difference is $\lambda W_Q(y_1) + (1-\lambda)W_Q(y_2)$, proving concavity. For upper semicontinuity, take $y_k \to y$ and a subsequence attaining the limsup of the widths. Compactness supplies a further subsequence whose endpoint pairs converge to $u, v \in F_Q(y)$. Its limiting difference is at most $W_Q(y)$.

For the transcript claim, fix the internal random seed. If no query is made, both fibers are F. Otherwise, any $z \in F_Q(y)$ gives the same answer to the first queried measurement. Inductively, equal previous answers produce the same next measurement and the same next answer. The stopping decision is also unchanged. Thus every completion agreeing with all queried answers follows the same entire transcript. Conversely, any completion consistent with that transcript must agree on every

queried answer. Query choices and the stopping time therefore impose no additional restrictions on the fiber beyond those exact observations. This argument is pointwise in the seed; no conditioning on a positive-probability seed event is required. □

2.3 Which width penalties can benefit from adaptation?

The next result uses classical minimax theory. The contribution is the resulting classification for sharp information-fiber widths and its coordinate-query converse, rather than a new minimax or duality theorem. The proof has two parts. For concave penalties, a single hardest record limits every final query set, including those chosen adaptively; Jensen's inequality supplies a batch policy meeting that limit. For any nonconcave penalty, a three-coordinate construction realizes a strict midpoint violation as an adaptive advantage. These arguments establish the universal claim; the later numerical checks test implementations on particular inputs.

Theorem 1 (Universal classification of width penalties)**.** *Let $\phi : [0, \infty) \to \mathbb{R}$ be finite-valued and nondecreasing. Randomized batch and randomized adaptive querying have equal minimax ϕ-risk for every problem satisfying Section 2.2 if and only if ϕ is concave. More precisely, put*

$$\rho = \min_{\pi \in \Delta(\mathcal{Q})} \max_{y \in F} \sum_{Q \in \mathcal{Q}} \pi_Q W_Q(y). \tag{5}$$

If ϕ is concave, then

$$R^{\phi}_{\text{adaptive}} = R^{\phi}_{\text{batch}} = \phi(\rho). \tag{6}$$

Every batch policy attaining (5) *simultaneously attains this equality for every such concave ϕ. If ϕ is not concave, a strict adaptive improvement already occurs on a three-coordinate compact convex polytope, with all coordinates queryable at unit cost and a hard budget of two.*

Proof. The function $\sum_Q \pi_Q W_Q(y)$ is affine and continuous in π, and concave and upper semicontinuous in y. Sion's minimax theorem (Sion, 1958) therefore yields

$$\rho = \max_{y \in F} \min_{Q \in \mathcal{Q}} W_Q(y). \tag{7}$$

All values are finite. Writing $G(\pi) = \max_{y \in F} \sum_Q \pi_Q W_Q(y)$, the bound $|G(\pi) - G(\pi')| \le D_T \|\pi - \pi'\|_1$ proves continuity. Thus the minimum in (5) is attained on the compact simplex. The maximum in (7) is attained because the minimum of finitely many upper semicontinuous functions is upper semicontinuous on compact F. Hence there is one record $y^\star \in F$ such that $W_Q(y^\star) \ge \rho$ for every admissible Q. By Proposition 1, every execution of every adaptive policy has terminal width at least ρ at this same record. Monotonicity gives the lower bound $\phi(\rho)$.

Let $\pi^\star$ attain (5). Concavity, Jensen's inequality, and monotonicity give, for every $y \in F$,

$$\sum_Q \pi^\star_Q \phi(W_Q(y)) \le \phi\left(\sum_Q \pi^\star_Q W_Q(y)\right) \le \phi(\rho).$$

This proves the upper bound and simultaneous optimality. No continuity of ϕ at zero is needed; the finite-mixture form of Jensen's inequality suffices. For example, $\phi(w) = \mathbf{1}\{w > 0\}$ is concave on $[0, \infty)$ despite its jump at zero.

For necessity, a nonconcave, nondecreasing finite-valued ϕ must have a strict midpoint-concavity violation: there exist $0 \le l < h$ such that, with $m = (l + h)/2$,

$$\phi(m) < \{\phi(l) + \phi(h)\}/2. \tag{8}$$

Indeed, if midpoint concavity held, for $0 \le x \le z$ and dyadic $q_k \uparrow \theta$ its dyadic inequalities and monotonicity would give

$$\phi((1-\theta)x + \theta z) \ge \phi((1-q_k)x + q_k z) \ge (1-q_k)\phi(x) + q_k\phi(z).$$

Taking the limit only on the right proves full concavity without a continuity assumption, a contradiction. Set $d_0 = h - l$ and consider

$$F_{l,h} = \{(a,b,c) : 0 \le a \le 1,\ 0 \le b \le l + d_0 a,\ 0 \le c \le h - d_0 a\}, \qquad T = ha + b + c. \tag{9}$$

All three coordinates are available at unit cost, with budget two. The widths after querying $\{a, b\}$ and $\{a, c\}$ are respectively $h - d_0 a$ and $l + d_0 a$. An adaptive policy first observes a and then queries the coordinate with the larger remaining capacity. Its terminal width is at most m, so its risk is at most $\phi(m)$. At $(a, b, c) = (1/2, 0, 0)$, these two widths equal m, while the width after querying $\{b, c\}$ is h. Thus every admissible terminal set has width at least m, and the adaptive optimum is exactly $\phi(m)$.

Now put equal adversarial mass on $(0, 0, 0)$ and $(1, 0, 0)$. Each batch $\{a, b\}$ or $\{a, c\}$ has average penalty $\{\phi(l) + \phi(h)\}/2$. The batch $\{b, c\}$ has width h at both records, so its average penalty is no smaller. A batch using fewer coordinates cannot improve upon an extension to two coordinates, because more observations only shrink the fiber. Every randomized batch policy consequently has worst-case risk at least $\{\phi(l) + \phi(h)\}/2 > \phi(m)$. This is the required strict separation. □

The universal quantifier is essential. A nonconcave penalty permits an adaptive advantage somewhere in this class; it need not yield an advantage for every feasible set. The theorem covers heterogeneous fixed costs and overlapping constraints at the level of information theory. It does not imply a polynomial-time optimizer for an arbitrary feasible set or budget.

2.3.1 A three-coordinate example

Take $0 \le a \le 1$, $0 \le b \le a$, $0 \le c \le 1 - a$, and $T = a + b + c$, with two unit-cost queries. The widths for batches $\{a, b\}$, $\{a, c\}$, and $\{b, c\}$ are $1 - a$, a, and $1 - b - c$. Querying a first and then c if $a \le 1/2$, or b otherwise, leaves width $\min(a, 1 - a) \le 1/2$.

Table 1: Exact constructed-example values. These are mathematical guarantees, not forecasting improvements measured on public data.

Criterion	Best randomized batch	Best adaptive policy
Worst expected width	1/2	1/2
Worst expected squared width	1/2	1/4
Worst-case success, width $\le 3/4$	1/2	1

An equal mixture of $\{a, b\}$ and $\{a, c\}$ attains the batch values. The endpoint records $(0, 0, 0)$ and $(1, 0, 0)$ give the corresponding batch lower bounds. At $(1/2, 0, 0)$ every admissible terminal set has width at least $1/2$, establishing the adaptive moment lower bounds. The precision separation holds for every threshold $1/2 \le \tau < 1$. Reaching a width threshold is distinct from certifying the sign of T: a narrow sharp interval may still contain zero.

2.4 Growing moment and precision separations

For $K \geq 2$, let $a_1, \ldots, a_K \geq 0$ sum to one and impose $0 \leq b_j \leq a_j$. The actual queryable coordinates are $a_1, \ldots, a_{K-1}, b_1, \ldots, b_K$; a_K is determined by the first $K-1$ capacities. Define

$$T = \sum_{i<K} a_i + \sum_{j=1}^{K} b_j, \qquad B = 2K - 2. \tag{10}$$

This is a compact convex polytope in $2K-1$ dimensions, and every coordinate has the same unit cost.

Theorem 2 (Sharp growing separations)**.** *For* (10)*, the optimal worst expected width is* $1/K$ *for both randomized batch and adaptive policies. For every* $p > 1$*,*

$$R^{w^p}_{\text{batch}} = 1/K, \qquad R^{w^p}_{\text{adaptive}} = 1/K^p. \tag{11}$$

For required width $\tau = 1/K$*, the best worst-case success probabilities are* $1/K$ *for randomized batches and* 1 *for adaptive policies.*

Proof. It suffices to consider batches using the full budget: adding observations cannot increase width. Such a batch omits exactly one coordinate. Omitting b_j leaves width a_j; omitting a_i, $i < K$, leaves width $a_i + a_K - b_i - b_K$. The latter follows because the remaining feasible range of a_i is $[b_i, a_i + a_K - b_K]$ and its coefficient in T is one. An adaptive policy queries all explicit capacities and then all b_j except one having the smallest capacity. Its width is $\min_j a_j \leq 1/K$. At the record with all $a_j = 1/K$ and all $b_j = 0$, every full-budget batch has width at least $1/K$. This proves the adaptive lower bounds and the mean-width lower bound.

The randomized batch policy omitting each b_j with probability $1/K$ has expected width exactly $1/K$. Its expected pth power is $K^{-1}\sum_j a_j^p \leq 1/K$, since $0 \leq a_j \leq 1$ and $p > 1$. For the reverse moment bound, average over the K records $a = e_j$, $b = 0$. A batch omitting a b_j has average pth-power width $1/K$; one omitting an explicit a_i has average $2/K$. Therefore every batch distribution has worst-case moment at least $1/K$.

For precision, omitting a uniformly random b_j succeeds with probability at least $1/K$ at every record, because at least one capacity is no greater than $1/K$. To prove the matching upper bound, use K records indexed by j, with $b = 0$,

$$a_j = \frac{1}{2K}, \qquad a_i = \frac{2K-1}{2K(K-1)} \quad (i \neq j).$$

These capacities sum to one. Only the batch omitting b_j reaches width at most $1/K$ at record j: every other b-omitting batch has larger width, and every a-omitting batch has width $a_i + a_K > 1/K$. If q_j is the probability of omitting b_j, worst-case success is at most $\min_j q_j \leq 1/K$. The adaptive policy always succeeds. The precision upper bound uses these interior capacity records; checking only vertices would not establish it. □

The moment ratio is K^{p-1}, while the ratio of worst-case success probabilities at precision $1/K$ is K. These separations use a structured constructed feasible set and a budget querying all but one coordinate. They establish the possible difference between objectives; they do not establish comparable gains at small relative budgets in a deployment or in the historical forecasting study.

2.5 Computing policies and hardest records on polytopes

Let $F = \{y \in \mathbb{R}^n : Ay \le b\}$ be nonempty and compact, and let $T(y) = c^\top y + d$. Equalities can be represented by paired inequalities. The constant d does not affect width. The first formulation allows any declared finite family $\mathcal{Q}$ of legal batches; L_Q denotes the matrix of their exact linear measurements.

2.5.1 An enumerative hardest-record formulation

Introduce a common record y, endpoint witnesses u_Q, v_Q for each $Q \in \mathcal{Q}$, and a scalar η. Consider

$$\begin{aligned} \max \quad & \eta \\ \text{subject to} \quad & Ay \le b, \quad Au_Q \le b, \quad Av_Q \le b \quad (Q \in \mathcal{Q}), \\ & L_Q u_Q = L_Q y, \quad L_Q v_Q = L_Q y \quad (Q \in \mathcal{Q}), \\ & \eta \le c^\top (u_Q - v_Q) \quad (Q \in \mathcal{Q}). \end{aligned} \tag{12}$$

For fixed y, the independent witnesses for batch Q can attain its sharp width $W_Q(y)$. Thus the largest feasible η at that record is $\min_Q W_Q(y)$, and the optimum of (12) is ρ. Its common record is a certificate that every legal batch leaves width at least ρ there.

The nonnegative dual multipliers π_Q of the last constraints form an optimal randomized batch policy. Indeed, the free variable η forces $\sum_Q \pi_Q = 1$. Dualizing these constraints first yields

$$\min_{\pi \in \Delta(\mathcal{Q})} \max_{y, u_Q, v_Q} \sum_Q \pi_Q c^\top (u_Q - v_Q) = \min_{\pi \in \Delta(\mathcal{Q})} \max_{y \in F} \sum_Q \pi_Q W_Q(y) = \rho,$$

where the endpoint feasibility constraints remain in the inner maximization. Ordinary linear-programming strong duality supplies the equality and the policy; no new duality theorem is asserted. In the implementation, a separate LP fixes the extracted π and maximizes its expected width, checking the upper bound independently of the constraints involving η.

With $M = |\mathcal{Q}|$ batches, the formulation has $n(1 + 2M) + 1$ variables. It is polynomial in the explicitly enumerated batch family, which may be exponential in the number of available measurements. It is a small-instance benchmark and certificate generator; the aggregate-specific compact formulation avoids this enumeration in its structured setting.

2.5.2 An exact deterministic two-query algorithm

Assume every one of the $n \ge 2$ coordinates is queryable at unit cost and the hard budget is two. An unused query can be added without increasing width, so considering two distinct coordinates includes policies that stop earlier. For a first query i and feasible answer t, define

$$g_{ij}(t) = \max\{c^\top (u - v) : Au \le b,\ Av \le b,\ u_i = v_i = t,\ u_j = v_j\}, \qquad j \ne i. \tag{13}$$

This maximizes the terminal width over all feasible records having first answer t, after second query j. The best deterministic policy beginning with i therefore has worst width $\rho_i = \max_t \min_{j \ne i} g_{ij}(t)$.

Proposition 2. *For each i, ρ_i is the value of the following single linear program, with one endpoint pair (u^j, v^j) for each $j \ne i$:*

$$\begin{aligned} \max \quad & \eta \\ \textit{subject to} \quad & Au^j \le b, \quad Av^j \le b \quad (j \ne i), \\ & (u^j)_i = (v^j)_i = t, \quad (u^j)_j = (v^j)_j \quad (j \ne i), \\ & \eta \le c^\top (u^j - v^j) \quad (j \ne i). \end{aligned} \tag{14}$$

The optimal deterministic adaptive two-query worst-width value is $\min_i \rho_i$.

Proof. At fixed feasible t, each endpoint pair has only its own constraints and can attain $g_{ij}(t)$. All inequalities on η are feasible precisely up to their smallest attainable upper bound, $\min_{j\neq i} g_{ij}(t)$. Maximizing over the shared t proves the first claim. For any deterministic policy beginning with i, its chosen second coordinate at answer t has conditional worst width at least $\min_j g_{ij}(t)$. Conversely, choosing a minimizing j after observing t attains that value. Finite tie breaking gives a measurable selection because these polyhedral value functions are piecewise linear on their feasible interval. Finally, minimize over the first coordinate. □

For rational input, n LPs of polynomial description size choose the first coordinate; after its answer, $n-1$ conditional LPs implement the second choice. This is a polynomial-time deterministic two-query procedure in the standard bit-complexity model, including the encoding length of rational query answers. For arbitrary exact answers, the policy is still defined by the conditional LPs; the polynomial bit-complexity statement applies to rationally encoded inputs and answers. It does not solve arbitrary-budget randomized precision-risk optimization or minimize expected requests until certification. No grid of possible first answers is used.

2.5.3 A precision consequence of sparse-policy bounds

The dimension bound below adapts established sparse-policy reasoning. Kurtz (2026, Theorem 2 and Example 5) gives the corresponding dimension-plus-one policy bound for continuous concave scenario costs, including conditional information discovery. Conditional terminal widths fit that framework on polytopes. The direct Helly proof below also allows compact convex F, for which these widths are upper semicontinuous but need not be continuous, and translates the sparse cover into precision success under uniform randomization.

Theorem 3 (A dimension-dependent batch guarantee, adapted from sparse-policy bounds)**.** *Let F be nonempty, compact and convex, and let $T(x) = c^\top x + d$. Fix a first-stage exact linear observation $L_0 x$, whose feasible-answer set $I = L_0 F$ has affine dimension r. After this answer, a deterministic policy chooses one of finitely many second-stage linear measurement batches $L_1, \dots, L_m$. Every combined batch (L_0, L_j) must obey the same declared hard budget, and the eligible second-stage batches must not depend on the first answer. Suppose the policy's terminal sharp interval has width at most τ for every $x \in F$. Then some randomized nonadaptive policy supported on at most $r+1$ of these combined batches has worst-case precision success at least $1/(r+1)$. In particular, a sure-precision policy using two scalar queries yields a randomized-batch success guarantee of at least $1/2$, even when its conditional worst widths are not affine functions of the first answer.*

Proof. For $t \in I$, define the conditional worst terminal width

$$g_j(t) = \max\{c^\top(u - v) : u, v \in F,\ L_0 u = L_0 v = t,\ L_j u = L_j v\}.$$

The feasible set is nonempty and compact, so the maximum is attained. The expression is exactly the largest terminal sharp width among records with first answer t: an endpoint pair with equal first and second answers belongs to a common terminal fiber, and the endpoints of every such fiber are feasible in this maximization.

Each g_j is concave on I. Indeed, convex combinations of optimizing endpoint pairs at t_1, t_2 are feasible at the corresponding convex combination of answers, and attain the same convex combination of their objective values. The function is also upper semicontinuous: for a convergent sequence

of answers, compactness gives convergent subsequences of optimizing endpoints, whose limits are feasible at the limiting answer. Consequently, g_j is finite and measurable.

For a fixed first answer, the policy chooses a single second-stage batch; its sure guarantee therefore implies $\min_j g_j(t) \le \tau$ throughout I. The strict failure sets

$$H_j = \{t \in I : g_j(t) > \tau\}$$

are convex by concavity, and $\bigcap_{j=1}^m H_j = \varnothing$. Finite Helly's theorem (Amenta et al., 2016, Theorem 1.1), applied in the affine hull of I, gives a subfamily J of at most $r+1$ sets with empty intersection. This finite form of Helly's theorem does not require the sets to be closed; thus using strict failure sets preserves success at equality with τ.

Choose uniformly among the combined batches indexed by J. For every fixed record x, its answer $t = L_0 x$ lies outside at least one H_j, so that batch's actual terminal width is at most $g_j(t) \le \tau$. Its precision success probability is therefore at least $1/|J|$, and hence at least $1/(r+1)$, for every record. □

The empty second-stage action includes stopping after the first stage. Fixed unequal costs are allowed if all combined batches obey the budget; the action dictionary and latent record are fixed before randomization. The K-capacity construction in Theorem 2 is sharp with first-answer dimension $r = K-1$ and optimal batch success $1/K$. For scalar first answers, at most two second-stage actions suffice to retain the optimal sure-width guarantee. On polytopes, test each singleton or pair of actions with the shared-first-answer LP in Proposition 2; there are at most $\binom{m}{2} + m$ candidates. This sparse policy need not minimize conditional width at every individual answer. Helly-based sparsification for convex-function optimization is classical (Rockafellar, 1965, Section 2, Theorem 1). The contribution here is its certificate-risk interpretation and sharpness through admissible information queries, rather than a new general sparse-policy theorem.

2.5.4 Adaptive precision from cumulative-counter queries

Consider a six-hour block with nonnegative hourly increments $z = (z_1, \dots, z_6)$ and retained cumulative registers C_0, C_6, all expressed in the same energy units. Writing $E = C_6 - C_0$, the initial feasible set is $F_E = \{z \ge 0 : \sum_{h=1}^6 z_h = E\}$. For two frozen forecast vectors a, b, their block MSE contrast is

$$D(z) = d + c^\top z, \qquad d = \frac{1}{6}\sum_{h=1}^6 (a_h^2 - b_h^2), \quad c_h = \frac{2(b_h - a_h)}{6}.$$

The permitted query at boundary $k \in \{1, \dots, 5\}$ returns C_k, equivalently the prefix sum $s_k = C_k - C_0$. The budget is at most two distinct internal registers per pair and block. This is a declared cumulative-register access interface, rather than the coordinate-increment interface of the earlier recovery experiment. The register queries are exact linear measurements covered by the general information model. Adaptive scalar certification also appears in monotone integral estimation (Gaillard et al., 2023, Section 4.1); here the target is an affine contrast of interval increments under a fixed hard budget.

For integer boundaries $0 \le p < q \le 6$, define $r(p,q) = \max_{p<h\le q} c_h - \min_{p<h\le q} c_h$. With queried boundaries Q, let $0 = q_0 < \cdots < q_m = 6$ include the outer boundaries and Q, and put $s_0 = 0$, $s_6 = E$. Nonnegativity and the segment totals give the sharp width

$$W_Q(z) = \sum_{\ell=1}^m (s_{q_\ell} - s_{q_{\ell-1}}) r(q_{\ell-1}, q_\ell). \tag{15}$$

Both endpoints are attainable by placing each segment's mass at a minimum- or maximum-coefficient hour. The initial width is $W_0 = Er(0,6)$. Tasks with $W_0 = 0$ are already precise and require no queries.

Proposition 3 (Two best-side splits for an arbitrary block)**.** *Let $n \geq 3$, $E > 0$, $x \geq 0$, $\sum_{h=1}^{n} x_h = E$, and let the target be $d + \sum_h c_h x_h$. Each query returns one internal prefix sum. Write $r(p,q) = \max_{p<h\leq q} c_h - \min_{p<h\leq q} c_h$. For first boundary k, put $\ell_k = r(0,k)$ and $r_k = r(k,n)$. Define each of the following quantities whenever its corresponding side has an eligible second boundary:*

$$\alpha_k = \min_{1\leq j<k} \max\{r(0,j), r(j,k)\}, \qquad \beta_k = \min_{k<j<n} \max\{r(k,j), r(j,n)\}.$$

Choose a minimizing boundary on each side, breaking ties by smallest index. When both sides are nonempty, for normalized first answer $t = s_k/E$, the optimal conditional worst width is

$$E \min\{\alpha_k t + r_k(1-t),\ \ell_k t + \beta_k(1-t)\}.$$

Thus only one best boundary on each side is needed, independently of t. If $\Delta_k = \ell_k + r_k - \alpha_k - \beta_k > 0$, the switch is

$$t_k^\star = \frac{r_k - \beta_k}{\Delta_k} \in [0,1],$$

and the worst width for this first boundary is

$$A_k = E \max\left\{\alpha_k, \beta_k, \frac{\ell_k r_k - \alpha_k \beta_k}{\Delta_k}\right\}.$$

Use the best right split below the switch and the best left split above it; either is valid at equality. If $\Delta_k = 0$, the two lines coincide and $A_k = E\max\{\ell_k, r_k\}$. At $k = 1$ only the right split exists and $A_1 = E\beta_1$; at $k = n-1$ only the left split exists and $A_{n-1} = E\alpha_{n-1}$. The optimal deterministic two-query guarantee is

$$A = \min_{1\leq k<n} A_k. \tag{16}$$

Proof. All second queries left of k have the common right-side contribution $r_k(1-t)$; minimizing their remaining term t times a split range selects the same minimizing boundary for every $t \geq 0$. The right-side argument is identical. Moreover $\alpha_k \leq \ell_k$ and $\beta_k \leq r_k$. Hence $\Delta_k \geq 0$, and when it is positive the displayed intersection belongs to $[0,1]$. The maximum of the lower envelope occurs at an endpoint or that intersection. Its endpoint values are β_k, α_k, and its intersection value is the displayed quotient. If $\Delta_k = 0$, both nonnegative differences vanish, so the lines coincide. At an outer eligible boundary the single-hour side has zero coefficient range, giving the stated one-line values. □

All contiguous ranges can be built in $O(n^2)$ arithmetic operations and stored in $O(n^2)$ space. Scanning the candidates for every α_k, β_k costs another $O(n^2)$ operations; the closed forms then cost $O(n)$. This is an arithmetic-operation bound for the exact-total, uncapped two-prefix problem, not a bit-complexity or noisy-polytope claim. For $n = 2$, the single internal register determines both increments; for $n = 1$ the total already determines the only increment.

An upper certificate for randomized-batch precision. Returning to the six-hour case, there are ten two-boundary batches. Let $z^{(h)} = Ee_h$ be the six feasible single-hour mass profiles, and define $M_{hQ}(\tau) = \mathbf{1}\{W_Q(z^{(h)}) \le \tau\}$. The finite-profile program

$$U(\tau) = \min_{w \ge 0,\, \sum_h w_h = 1,\, u} u \quad \text{subject to} \quad \sum_h w_h M_{hQ}(\tau) \le u \quad \text{for every batch } Q \tag{17}$$

upper-bounds the worst-case precision success of *every* randomized batch policy. Indeed, its minimum success over F_E is at most its success averaged over these profiles under w, which is at most $\max_Q \sum_h w_h M_{hQ}$. This remains valid for batches with fewer queries: adding an unused register cannot increase width. The exported w therefore provides a checkable upper certificate. The finite profile set need not contain a worst completion for an indicator objective, so $U(\tau)$ is not asserted to equal the full precision optimum in general. Below, write $S_B^\star = S_\tau^{\text{batch}}$ and $S_A = S_\tau^{\text{adaptive}}$ for the precision-success values defined in (4), at this fixed instance and threshold. If $A \le \tau$ and $U(\tau) < 1$, the adaptive policy succeeds for every completion, whereas no randomized batch can do so. In floating-point classification, batch widths within $10^{-9}W_0$ above the threshold count as success, and adaptive certification requires a margin of $10^{-9}W_0$; exact constructed boundary cases are treated analytically.

An exact counter example. Take $E = 1$ and $c = (0, 0, 1, 1, 0, 1)$, so $W_0 = 1$. Query boundary 4 first, obtaining $t = s_4$. Batch $\{2, 4\}$ has width $1 - t$, while batch $\{4, 5\}$ has width t. Querying 5 when $t < 1/2$ and 2 otherwise thus guarantees width $\min\{t, 1 - t\} \le 1/2$. Conversely, at $z = e_5$ only batch $\{4, 5\}$ attains width below 1; that batch has width 1 at $z = e_2$. No batch succeeds at both profiles for any threshold $\tau < 1$. Weights $w_2 = w_5 = 1/2$ in (17) give $U \le 1/2$. An equal mixture of $\{2, 4\}$ and $\{4, 5\}$ succeeds with probability at least $1/2$ on every completion when $\tau \ge 1/2$. Consequently, for every $\tau \in [1/2, 1)$ the optimal adaptive worst-case success is 1 and the optimal randomized-batch worst-case success is $1/2$. These are exact mathematical values, not measured application performance or acquisition-cost savings.

Corollary 1 (The two-register half-success floor)**.** *If a deterministic two-register policy guarantees width at most τ, a randomized batch supported on at most two batches has worst-case precision success at least $1/2$. Thus an adverse-profile upper bound $U(\tau) = 1/2$ proves the exact batch optimum for such an instance.*

Proof. Apply Theorem 3 with scalar first answer. For the exact-total prefix model the conditional functions are affine: their good sets are prefixes or suffixes of $[0, 1]$. The longest good prefix and earliest good suffix cover all answers; mix their batches equally, breaking geometric ties by smallest second-query index. □

Corollary 2 (Deciding whether feedback is necessary)**.** *In the cumulative-counter model, let $\mathcal{B}$ contain the ten two-register batches, and define*

$$D = \min_{Q \in \mathcal{B}} \max_{z \in F_E} W_Q(z) = \min_{Q \in \mathcal{B}} \max_{1 \le h \le 6} W_Q(Ee_h).$$

Let A be the exact deterministic adaptive value in (16)*, and let $U(\tau)$ be the finite-profile upper certificate in* (17)*. For every $\tau \ge 0$,*

$$D \le \tau \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad U(\tau) = 1 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad S_B^\star = 1.$$

Consequently, the available forecasts and outer registers determine three mutually exclusive decisions before any optional retrieval:

1. *If $D \le \tau$, a fixed batch guarantees the requested precision.*

2. *If $A \le \tau < D$, feedback enables a deterministic guarantee that every randomized batch fails to match.*

3. *If $\tau < A$, no deterministic adaptive policy with two register queries guarantees the requested precision.*

In the second case, $1/2 \le S_B^\star \le U(\tau) \le 5/6$. *The lower bound uses Corollary 1; when* $U(\tau) = 1/2$, *the randomized-batch optimum is exactly* $1/2$.

Proof. For a fixed batch, (15) is a linear function of z. It therefore attains its maximum over the energy simplex at a concentration profile Ee_h, which proves the expression for D. If $D \le \tau$, one batch succeeds at all six profiles and, by linearity, at every completion. Thus $S_B^\star = 1$ and $U(\tau) = 1$. If $D > \tau$, every batch fails at at least one profile. The uniform distribution on the six profiles consequently assigns every batch success probability at most $5/6$. It is a feasible adverse distribution in (17), so $S_B^\star \le U(\tau) \le 5/6 < 1$. This proves both equivalences. Adaptation includes fixed batches, hence $A \le D$. The three cases then follow from the defining optimality of A and D. □

This decision rule uses only the forecast coefficients, retained total, query dictionary and requested precision. It identifies when a sequential query response is necessary for a guarantee, without measuring retrieval latency, financial cost or the frequency of adverse energy profiles. The finite-profile program is decisive for whether batch success equals one; it remains only an upper bound on intermediate success values unless a matching guarantee is supplied.

3 Results

The application asks which admissible retrieval method meets a required precision. It separates information available before a query, guarantees over all compatible records, replay on recorded answers, and actual API measurements. All policies in each comparison share the same initial information and measurement model. Scalar readings, network requests and feedback rounds are different resources. The protocol must identify which resource is limited before comparing methods.

3.1 When two counter readings need feedback

The first replay uses three actual cumulative consumption counters (Kostmann and Härdle, 2019), 91 eligible days per meter, and four frozen forecasters (persistence, ridge, boosted trees and an MLP). Each of their six pairs is audited on six-hour blocks ending at 06:00, 12:00 and 18:00 UTC: 4,914 tasks in total. The auditor receives the block's endpoint counters and day-start forecasts. Next-day persistence copies are unavailable at these intraday cutoffs under the declared issue schedule. No production arrival times are inferred. Source and fitting details are in Online Resource 1, S3.

The restricted interface offers five internal hourly counters and a budget of two scalar readings per standalone pair/block audit. This is a specified access replay, not a provider tariff or a demonstrated deployed service. Hourly-increment queries and bulk exports are separate interfaces, examined below. Every policy uses the same retained total, nonnegativity constraints and forecast-derived coefficients. The primary target, fixed before the geometry and answer replay, is $W \le W_0/2$. This is a precision requirement; it need not establish which model wins. Query choices use only permitted

information and previous queried answers. Unqueried answers enter outcome evaluation after the choice. The shared preparation files are not physically isolated, so this is an audited dependency rule rather than a security boundary.

Table 2 gives the complete decision partition. A fixed batch suffices on 88.95% of tasks. Feedback changes the attainable deterministic guarantee on 5.90%, spanning all three meters and all six model pairs. The remaining 5.15% require more information, a larger budget or a weaker requirement. The first 20 days per meter contributed 1,080 tasks; the unchanged continuation contributed 3,834. These reused meters are not an untouched-source replication.

Table 2: Decisions before optional answers, at $W \le W_0/2$ with two readings. "Feedback needed" means $A \le \tau < D$; "unresolved" means $\tau < A$ for deterministic policies. All 290 feedback cases have exact optimal randomized-batch worst-case success 1/2.

Meter	Tasks	Fixed batch suffices	Feedback needed	Unresolved
1	1,638	1,460	97	81
2	1,638	1,430	103	105
3	1,638	1,481	90	67
All	4,914	4,371	290	253

For every feedback case, a constructed equal mixture of two batches succeeds on at least half of all random choices at every feasible record. A finite adverse-profile certificate gives the reverse bound for every randomized batch. These establish a continuum optimum, not just a sampled upper bound: $S_B^\star \ge 1/2$ and $S_B^\star \le 1/2$. Consequently, the minimum, quartiles, median and maximum of the 290 exact bounds all equal 1/2; none is below 40% or 30%. Corollary 1 explains this structural floor. The worked example below supplies the complete argument for one recorded comparison. S6 retains the earliest qualifying witness from each meter, including exact coefficients, covers and adverse weights.

One fully inspectable recorded comparison. Take meter 1, persistence versus boosting, 1 October 2017, 06:00–12:00 UTC, the earliest qualifying case for that meter. Its retained total is $E = 4.6129961798$ kWh. With $z = y/E$ and $q = (c - \min c)/(\max c - \min c)$, we have $z \ge 0$, $\sum_h z_h = 1$ and W/W_0 equal to the width of $q^\top z$. Exact conversion of the saved coefficients gives the following outward enclosures; every displayed endpoint is an exact decimal rational:

$$q \in \{1\} \times [.9061, .9062] \times \{0\} \times [.5717, .5718] \times [.8607, .8608] \times [.2988, .2989].$$

The initial squared-loss width satisfies $1.31295 < W_0 = E(\max c - \min c) < 1.31296$; the required width is $\tau = W_0/2$ (approximately 0.656478).

Query boundary 3 first and observe $t = z_1 + z_2 + z_3$. Query boundary 5 if $t \le 1/4$, and boundary 2 otherwise. The coefficient enclosures alone give the conditional bounds

$$\begin{aligned} t + .2891(1-t) &\le .466825, && 0 \le t \le 1/4, \\ .0939t + .5620(1-t) &\le .444975, && 1/4 \le t \le 1. \end{aligned}$$

Both are strictly below 1/2, proving success for every feasible record.

For the matching batch limitation, place adverse probability 1/2 each on $z = e_2$ and $z = e_5$. The table lists success at the same half-width threshold for all ten batches ($ij = \{i, j\}$); the enclosures certify every entry.

Batch	12	13	14	15	23	24	25	34	35	45
e_2	1	0	0	0	1	1	1	0	0	0
e_5	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1

Every column averages at most $1/2$, limiting every randomized batch. Conversely, an equal mixture of $\{3, 5\}$ and $\{2, 3\}$ succeeds on at least one branch for every t, giving the continuum lower bound $1/2$. Thus $S_A = 1$ and $S_B^\star = 1/2$. Smaller batches cannot improve precision. Online Resource 1 retains the exact coefficients and an independent rational checker for this printed witness. This is the existing exact-total case; it is not a new sample or a measurement-error guarantee.

The replay compares exact adaptive worst-width planning, the best fixed worst-width batch, a mean-width-optimal randomized batch, uniform batching and greedy adaptation. Greedy's first-query ties use the best two-query guarantee; its second query minimizes conditional worst width. Batch ties minimize uniform-vertex mean width. The mean-optimal policy uses that same answer-independent secondary criterion on its optimal face. Randomized outcomes are exact expectations over ten batch probabilities. The added precision-optimal cover is defined only on the 290-case subset and uses coefficient-based, answer-independent tie breaking.

Table 3: Recorded replay, two readings per audit. P: precision success; W: mean width relative to W_0; O: interval excludes zero. All entries are percentages. The subset is selected by pre-answer guarantees.

	All 4,914 tasks			290-case subset		
Policy	P	W	O	P	W	O
Exact adaptive	98.64	18.59	50.49	100.00	33.72	28.97
Best deterministic batch	98.23	18.87	49.84	97.24	35.28	25.52
Mean-optimal random batch	92.68	22.83	45.42	80.01	41.21	24.43
Precision-optimal cover	–	–	–	75.34	43.12	22.76
Uniform random batch	63.04	42.59	24.79	41.79	53.10	18.76
Greedy adaptive	97.96	18.84	50.33	96.21	34.67	28.62

The large worst-case success gap is not a large average replay gain. Relative to the best deterministic batch, adaptation gains 0.407 percentage points over all tasks: 30 are adaptive-only successes and ten are batch-only successes. On the subset, eight are adaptive-only and none batch-only. The precision-optimal cover can perform worse on recorded answers than policies optimizing other risks. The prespecified 10% prevalence target was not met (5.90%); it is not replaced by a secondary threshold. All five predeclared precision fractions, paired ordering outcomes and per-meter summaries remain in S6. Blocks and model pairs are dependent.

A post-analysis implementation uses a guaranteeing fixed batch on the 4,371 eligible tasks and the adaptive rule elsewhere. It preserves precision success at every completion while removing the need for feedback on 88.95% of tasks. Both versions reach 98.64% recorded success; mean width changes from 18.59% to 18.72% of W_0. This saves a dependency between answers, not readings, and is not a measured latency saving.

Exact rational checks reconstruct every batch and adaptive envelope. Raw-source replay reproduces all 24,570 policy evaluations and 49,140 batch intervals with no containment or success discrepancy. Independent endpoint LPs and scale-aware tolerances are documented in S6; source calendars, integer counter subtraction and all 6,552 frozen forecast rows are checked. The geometric separation is proved on the stated record model; these checks do not establish physical meter accuracy.

Sensitivity to additional hourly information. Before computing this sensitivity, we fixed the subset to all 290 original feedback-essential cases and the illustrative caps $0 \le x_h \le E/2$ and $0 \le x_h \le E/3$. These are scenario constraints, not validated physical limits. The primary comparison keeps the original absolute requirement $\tau = W_0^{\text{old}}/2$. A separate calculation halves the new constrained width and therefore asks a different precision question (Table 4).

Table 4: Illustrative-cap sensitivity of the fixed 290-case subset. Each row partitions all cases into a fixed-batch guarantee, a feedback-essential deterministic guarantee, and no deterministic two-query guarantee. "Old" and "new" identify the initial width used in the threshold, not different data.

Hourly cap	Precision threshold	Batch	Feedback	Unresolved
None	$W_0^{\text{old}}/2$	0	290	0
$E/2$	$W_0^{\text{old}}/2$	282	8	0
$E/3$	$W_0^{\text{old}}/2$	290	0	0
$E/2$	$W_0^{\text{new}}/2$	163	33	94
$E/3$	$W_0^{\text{new}}/2$	221	0	69

At the unchanged requirement, the $E/2$ cap leaves eight feedback-essential cases, five on meter 1 and three on meter 2; all retain exact randomized-batch success 1/2. The $E/3$ cap leaves none; 34 cases already satisfy the old threshold without a query. The constructed example $E = 1$, $c = (0, 0, 1, 1, 0, 1)$ illustrates the mechanism: imposing $x_h \le 1/2$ changes the best fixed-batch guarantee from one to 1/2, matching adaptation, while its initial width remains one. Thus the original guarantee gap is sensitive to additional valid hourly information; it is not established as robust to physical capacity bounds.

After freezing the capped geometry, an exact integer-register check found that the recorded trace violates the $E/2$ assumption in 8 of 290 cases (meters 1–3: 1, 0, 7) and the $E/3$ assumption in 57 cases (11, 8, 38). These correspond to 8 and 48 of the 228 distinct blocks. All cases remain in Table 4; the capped guarantees do not cover an excluded trace. Compatibility does not establish a physical operating bound. None of the eight remaining feedback-essential cases at the unchanged threshold violates the $E/2$ cap in its recorded trace; the eight excluded cases form a different set.

All results use the original coefficients and total. Exact rational bounded-allocation formulas and independently assembled polytope LPs agree across every case, batch and first query; the largest discrepancy is 6.11×10^{-16} in units of W_0^{old}. Finite adverse games use only exactly feasible capped profiles. Their upper bounds are called exact continuum optima only when a matching fixed-batch or two-batch guarantee is supplied. The fixed protocol, 1,740-row ledger, coefficients and checkable witnesses are included in Online Resource 1. This calculation does not estimate full-panel prevalence or measured acquisition savings.

3.2 Replication on an external stored-counter source

We froze a public-source protocol for HeatpumpMonitor.org (OpenEnergyMonitor, 2026a,b) before fitting forecasts or evaluating acquisition outcomes. The ascending-ID screen required public MID status, explicit Class-1 electrical-meter metadata and a cumulative electrical-energy feed spanning January–July 2025. The first three qualifiers were systems 1, 2 and 7: systems 3 and 6 lacked MID status, while 4 and 5 failed calendar coverage. The source rule was locked before hourly retrieval. Detailed training gates were fixed after training-only inspection but before July retrieval; all three systems met the requirements of at least 95% valid hourly intervals and 90 complete training days,

without replacement. Bundled metadata, request logs and protocol locks expose this chronology and every exclusion. January–June 2025 supplied training data; July supplied 31 test days per system. The four existing model specifications were fitted once, without retuning or replacement. All three six-hour blocks and six model pairs were retained, giving 1,674 tasks with no reference-data attrition and no zero-width case. The half-initial-width target, five optional internal cumulative samples and two-sample budget were unchanged.

The target here is the difference of consecutive hourly *API-grid stored cumulative samples*. The interface can label a selected native sample with a grid timestamp (OpenEnergyMonitor, 2026c). Native acquisition and historical delivery times are unavailable, so chronological forecast features are established on the declared grid, not as measured midnight production availability. The exact stored-sample model does not assert exact physical energy or unconditional Class-1 pointwise error bounds.

The exact triage found 1,614 tasks with a guaranteeing fixed batch, 29 requiring feedback for a deterministic half-width guarantee, and 31 without such a two-query adaptive guarantee. The 29 cases span all three systems (2, 14 and 13 cases) and all six model pairs. Each has matching rational adverse-profile and all-completion covering witnesses proving optimal randomized-batch worst-case success exactly 1/2; adaptation guarantees success one. All 29 batch optima are exactly 1/2, including their minimum, median and quartiles.

Table 5: External stored-sample replay. Success is the probability of reaching half initial width. Randomized outcomes average the declared mixture exactly over its finite support. The cover policy is specified only on the 29 cases with certified batch optimum 1/2. Full recovery uses all five optional samples, outside the two-sample budget; its actual API request cost is compared in Section 3.3.

Policy	All-task success (%)	29-case success (%)	29-case mean W/W_0
Exact adaptive	99.223	100.000	0.3113
Best deterministic worst-width batch	99.104	96.552	0.3736
Greedy adaptive	99.104	100.000	0.3114
Mean-width-optimal batch	95.250	82.004	0.4003
Precision-optimal covering batch	—	81.034	0.3942
Uniform batch	63.053	34.138	0.5899
Full stored-trace recovery	100.000	100.000	0.0000

In recorded replay, exact adaptation and the best deterministic batch both succeed in 1,658 tasks; only adaptation succeeds in three, only the batch in one, and neither in twelve. The net observed gain is therefore two tasks, or 0.119 percentage points. Ordering certification is 91.219% versus 90.741%, with 14 adaptive-only and six batch-only decisions. The replication extends the information-model separation to a new source; it does not demonstrate a large improvement over an ordinary adaptive policy or the provider's permitted full-range retrieval. These dependent tasks represent three systems, not 1,674 independent deployments. Section 3.3 compares that full-range alternative under the actual provider interface and measured request times.

A separate internal checker verifies 16,740 terminal intervals by exact rational arithmetic, all 29 matching half-success witnesses, and the two-side adaptive formula for every positive-width task. Independent fiber LPs for the earliest task in each system–pair group (360 solves) agree with the interval endpoints to 2.78×10^{-17}; solver feasibility tolerance is 10^{-9} and comparison tolerance 2×10^{-8}. All 2,232 saved persistence values equal the corresponding prior-day grid differences. This is independent implementation checking within the study, not an external human validation.

Measurement uncertainty and a sufficient reading budget. We retain all 29 external half-separation cases and ask whether feedback's assurance advantage survives errors in the retrieved internal readings. Normalize the retained total to one and divide the original coefficient vector by its positive range, without translation. Certificate-LP widths are then measured in units of the original W_0, with initial width one. The hidden record consists of $y_h \geq 0$, $\sum_h y_h = 1$, and five fixed errors $e_k \in [-\delta, \delta]$; query k returns $\sum_{h \leq k} y_h + e_k$. Errors are fixed before policy randomization. The endpoints remain exact, and no hourly cap is imposed in this separate sensitivity calculation. Before solving, we fixed $\delta \in \{0, 0.001, 0.01\}$ and the unchanged requirement $W \leq W_0/2$. Initial width remains W_0, so halving the new initial width gives the same threshold. These allowances concern block-total units; they are illustrative bounds, not calibrated physical-device specifications.

Table 6: Guarantees certified on the fixed 29-case external subset under bounded internal-readout errors and exact endpoints. Every passing case has adaptive worst-case success one and optimal randomized-batch worst-case success exactly 1/2. All six model pairs are represented at each level. Exact lower witnesses rule out a deterministic two-query guarantee in the remaining cases.

Error allowance	Certified cases	System 1	System 2	System 7
0	29/29	2/2	14/14	13/13
$0.001E$	27/29	2/2	13/14	12/13
$0.01E$	22/29	2/2	12/14	8/13

Two solver-free checkers verify all 49 positive-error certificates using exact rational weak duality and an explicit correction for residuals in the proposed multipliers. The smallest certified margin below $W_0/2$ exceeds $0.003759W_0$. The complete LPs, multipliers, finite variable bounds and derivation are in Online Resource 1, S6. These are upper guarantees for the saved first-query/successor supports, not claims of exact optimal-width values.

The original batch upper bound 1/2 survives because zero-error records and fibers remain feasible. The two-successor guarantee supplies the matching continuum lower bound. Thus the exact separation survives in 27 and 22 cases, spanning every system and model pair. Independent error-eliminated LPs reproduce all 87 case–level calculations with maximum discrepancy 1.89×10^{-15}.

For the remaining two cases at $0.001E$ and seven at $0.01E$, every legal first query k has a rational answer t_k such that, for each possible second query j, two feasible latent records share first answer t_k and an identical second answer, while their target contrast exceeds $W_0/2$. Every deterministic two-query policy therefore has a permitted failing record; stopping early cannot help. Two exact checkers verify 45 first-answer witnesses and 180 endpoint pairs, with minimum strict excess $5.9060 \times 10^{-6} W_0$. The loss of the guarantee is caused by larger observational fibers, not LP tie breaking. No randomized-adaptive impossibility is asserted.

A certified budget fallback covering all 29 cases. A post-analysis calculation keeps the cases, $0.01E$ allowance, exact endpoints and precision threshold, and permits a third reading. Among 899 fixed-batch LPs, exact upper certificates identify a three-reading batch for every case; the largest upper bound is $0.458896W_0$. The implemented rule chooses two adaptive readings for 22 cases and a fixed three-reading batch for seven, before inspecting optional answers. It guarantees precision in all 29 cases.

Its two-query branches minimize certified affine upper bounds by exact rational comparisons, without online LPs. Their lower envelope is at most $W_0/2$ on the whole first-answer interval $[-0.01, 1.01]$. Separate tests cover 1,015 constructed executions and reject incompatible transcripts.

The continuum guarantee comes from the certificates, not these tests. This executable branch rule can differ from the earlier conditional-width minimizer, so its recorded replay figures are not reused.

Table 7: Post-analysis budget fallback on the unchanged 29-case external subset at $0.01E$ internal error. Totals sum hard reading allowances across separate pairwise audits; they are not measured API requests or costs.

Policy	Guaranteed cases	Maximum budget	Total allowances
Two-query adaptive	22/29	2	58
Minimum fixed-batch budgets	29/29	3	87
Certified two-or-three rule	29/29	3	65

These are the minimum per-case deterministic hard budgets: a one-query policy is a fixed batch and cannot guarantee the threshold on any of these cases; the seven lower witnesses additionally rule out two-query policies. The upper certificates attain the corresponding budgets of two and three. Every nonadaptive batch with at most two queries still has a failing completion, so randomization cannot give sure success using any such batch with positive probability. Thus three readings per case also attain the minimum nonadaptive budget for sure success. The reduction from 87 to 65 is $22/87 = 25.29\%$ in reserved readings on this selected subset. It does not optimize expected stopping costs, share readings across model pairs, or change the original two-query result; full-range retrieval remains the preferred option on the measured public API.

3.3 Retrieval interface and measured operational consequences

The public source permits both single-time and full-range queries (OpenEnergyMonitor, 2026b,c). We therefore tested the latter as an operational comparator instead of treating a two-reading budget as a measured tariff. The first eligible daily-persistence–MLP task from each external system was fixed before retrieving optional answers. Two repetitions of five policies produced 30 trials and 60 actual HTTP requests, including six common endpoint reads. The protocol limited request starts to one per second, with no retries or cache-busting. All trials succeeded; timings include the recorded persistent-connection behavior and uncontrolled public cache/server state.

Table 8: Actual public-API measurements on three fixed tasks, two repetitions per policy. Incremental I/O excludes the separately logged client throttle wait. Bytes are response-body bytes, not wire traffic. The full-range interface returns seven hourly samples in one request, including retained endpoints; it is an operational alternative outside the two-optional-sample benchmark budget.

Policy	Requests	Mean I/O (s)	Mean body bytes
Exact adaptive	2	0.497	104.3
Best deterministic worst-width batch	2	0.539	104.7
Mean-width-optimal batch	2	0.582	104.3
Greedy adaptive	2	0.551	104.3
Full hourly range	1	0.331	226.7

All five policies attained the precision target on these three traces. Bulk retrieval used fewer requests and less observed I/O time, while also reducing terminal width to zero. Selective retrieval reduced body size by about 122 bytes; this small difference excludes HTTP/TLS overhead and does

not establish an operational saving. A range returning only the five internal samples could reduce the bulk response further. Including the imposed client throttle, mean completion times were 1.984 seconds for exact adaptation and 1.040 seconds for bulk retrieval; these are not intrinsic provider latencies. The small workload does not support a population speedup or monetary-cost claim.

An offline checker matches all 60 received payload hashes to separately cached source responses, checks all 12 adaptive second-query decisions and all 30 interval containments (maximum discrepancy 1.74×10^{-18}). Each result can be verified without repeating provider traffic. The appropriate decision for this observed interface is bulk retrieval when its unrestricted response is admissible. The two-query separation instead answers the distinct question posed by a fixed sample budget; it does not override an available cheaper interface.

Selecting the acquisition protocol. The interface, budget unit and operational preference must be specified before an acquisition guarantee is used. A reference implementation selects among the supplied fixed, adaptive and full-range certificates for the 29 cases. It checks permitted queries, scalar-reading and information-round caps, transport grouping, and the requested preference; a missing guarantee triggers escalation rather than a relaxed target. This is an integration of the preceding results, not a new optimization theorem. A frozen offline evaluation retains all 29 external cases, the exact endpoint total, the $0.01E$ stored-readout allowance and the unchanged half-width target.

Unrestricted range retrieval is preferred on the actual public interface. Its five internal values contain each case's certified three-query subset, so information monotonicity preserves the precision guarantee under bounded stored-readout errors; it does not imply zero uncertainty about true increments. The restricted three-reading rule reserves 65 scalar observations in 51 information rounds, whereas the one-round-per-case rule reserves 87 in 29 rounds. These are distinct resources. HTTP counts are left unspecified for the hypothetical restricted interfaces. In particular, an interface offering a single native multipoint request can favor fixed-three under request priority while favoring adaptive-two under reading priority.

The preceding three-task API timings support bulk selection on that service; they are not measurements on this 29-case sensitivity subset. The supplement exports all 116 case–interface decisions, exclusions and certificate hashes, with an offline callback dispatcher and separate verification. The implementation returns an auditable acquisition plan: a supported case, its measurement assumptions, selected query protocol, hard resource allowances and the certificate proving its precision. If no supplied plan meets the interface, it returns escalation. This catalogue decision alone does not prove that every possible policy fails; the seven deterministic two-query exclusions additionally have the exact lower witnesses described above.

The operational wrapper binds each supplied certificate to its saved model pair, exact coefficients, meter, API-grid block, retained endpoints and source hashes; readout envelopes with a different task, timestamp, feed or unit are rejected. For example, the system 1 ridge–MLP comparison on 6 July 2025, 12:00–18:00 UTC, uses boundary 2 followed by boundary 1 or 4 under the restricted two-reading rule, while its public-interface plan selects bulk retrieval. These are checks against accidental task mismatch and a worked planning example; measured API trials and constructed dispatch tests remain separate, and the wrapper does not authenticate a provider or calibrate a meter.

A reading–feedback cost frontier. A post-analysis calculation makes the protocol choice explicit without assigning an unmeasured monetary benefit. Let $c_{\mathrm{read}} > 0$ charge for a reserved scalar reading and $c_{\mathrm{round}} \geq 0$ for an information round; write $r = c_{\mathrm{round}}/c_{\mathrm{read}}$. Under the restricted in-

Table 9: Protocol selection under four explicitly declared interfaces. The restricted interfaces are benchmark assumptions; the public API permits bulk retrieval. All rows use the same 29 cases and uncertainty model.

Interface and preference	Certified	Selected protocol
Range available; fewest requests	29/29	Bulk range in all 29
Three readings, two rounds; fewest readings	29/29	Adaptive two in 22; fixed three in seven
Two readings, two rounds	22/29	Adaptive two in 22; escalate seven
Three readings, one round	29/29	Fixed three in all 29

terface, each of the 22 cases admitting the certified adaptive rule costs $2 + 2r$ in reading units, versus $3 + r$ for its certified fixed batch. Thus feedback is preferable exactly when $r < 1$. The seven remaining cases use fixed-three under both complete-coverage baselines. Over the same 29 cases, fixed-three costs $87 + 29r$, adaptive-where-certified with fixed fallback costs $65 + 51r$, and the catalogue selector attains their minimum. Ties favor fewer rounds.

Table 10: Declared-cost sensitivity on the unchanged 29-case subset at 1% internal error and exact endpoints. Costs are reading-charge units, not measured prices or latency. All methods retain the same precision guarantee.

r	Fixed-three	Adaptive with fixed fallback	Catalogue choice
0	87	65	65
0.25	94.25	77.75	77.75
0.5	101.5	90.5	90.5
1	116	116	116
2	145	167	145
4	203	269	203

Neither baseline is uniformly inferior: fixed-three is already optimal within this catalogue when $r \geq 1$, and adaptive with fallback is optimal when $r \leq 1$. The benefit is preventing an acquisition choice that assigns priority to the wrong resource. The analysis uses exact rational arithmetic, exports all 174 case–ratio choices with their certificates, and independently checks all 306 candidate evaluations. It is separable across pairwise audits; shared readings, stopping costs and unlisted protocols are outside this calculation. The existing three-task public-API measurements remain separate: mean I/O was 0.331 s for bulk and 0.497 s for adaptive retrieval, supporting bulk on that admissible interface. Those observations do not calibrate r or turn the modeled frontier into measured savings.

3.4 Computability and proof checks

The proofs establish the universal classification. Numerical checks address the implementation separately: 3,202 endpoint LPs and 28 finite games agree with the analytic constructions, with largest width discrepancy 3.34×10^{-16} against a 2×10^{-8} scale-aware tolerance. Six explicit polytopes check overlapping constraints, signed contrasts, boxes and coupled capacities. All 37 enumerated batches and 24 possible first queries agree with the corresponding LP guarantees. These are small formulation checks, not a general scalability claim.

For coordinate queries under disjoint exact totals and unit costs, a supporting compact mean-width solver avoids enumerating batches. Its retained-endpoint flow representation and feasible

dual completion and adaptive lower-bound proof are given in Online Resource 1, S5; S7 supplies the measured comparisons. General weighted-oracle and dynamic-program LP constructions are established (Kawase and Sumita, 2024; Martin et al., 1990). The specialized representation and its hard-budget policy decomposition are the implementation contribution.

All 28 archived compact settings solved. Twelve prescribed enumerated comparisons agreed within 1.27×10^{-15} after normalization. Compact was faster in eight and used less whole-process peak memory in six; enumeration was faster in the four smallest one-block settings. The largest tested LP had 38,820 variables and ran in 9.933–10.012 seconds for 48 target coordinates. These are single-run measurements on a shared Intel Core i7-8565U host with one numerical thread. The complete timing, memory, residual, tie-profile and skip ledgers are in S1/S7. No large-scale optimizer for arbitrary convex sets or precision risk is implied.

3.5 Historical controls: guarantees and observed accuracy

The earlier completed-archive study (Trindade, 2015; Hebrail and Berard, 2006) incorporates every permitted forecast copy before evaluation. Under identical information and zero new readings, paired bounds certify 7,836/9,720 Portugal comparisons (80.62%), versus 2,513 (25.85%) from separate-loss bounds. However, a donor imputer makes no observed whole-period errors at full coverage; the added value is an all-completions certificate, not demonstrated prediction accuracy. In the daily archive analysis, free reconstruction already resolves 95.33% of masked targets, exact acquisition adds only 0.042 percentage points over greedy, and robust randomization worsens realized width despite improving its objective. Outcome-independent optimal-face refinements retain that tradeoff (Iancu and Trichakis, 2014). The earlier 0.9738064% mean acquisition saving and its denominator remain unchanged. S2–S4 retain these adverse controls, all 324 grid cells, four-model gates, bootstrap details and full protocols. They explain why the present paper evaluates the assurance requirement and retrieval interface explicitly rather than claiming general acquisition savings.

4 Discussion

4.1 What the method changes in an audit

The practical output is a justified acquisition choice. The auditor first states the contrast to compare, the precision required, the information already available, and the retrieval options. A sufficient initial interval needs no query. Otherwise, a bulk response or fixed batch can avoid feedback; adaptive retrieval is useful when it meets the required guarantee with fewer permitted readings. This ordering prevents a sophisticated selective policy from being used where a simpler service already supplies adequate information.

The public API is a concrete example. Its full-range response is admissible, uses one request, and is faster on the measured three-task workload. The selector therefore recommends bulk. Under the separate restricted-reading contract, the same assurance analysis instead justifies 22 two-reading and seven three-reading prescriptions. The contracts limit different resources: 65 versus 87 counts reserved scalar readings across the selected 29 audits, while 51 versus 29 counts information rounds. A service that values rounds more than readings can reasonably choose fixed batches. Actual monetary costs and service-wide latency require corresponding operational measurements.

Breadth of the theory and limits of the implementations. The classification applies to any known compact convex feasible set, scalar affine target, finite exact-linear query dictionary and answer-independent family of legal final query sets. It permits signed targets, overlapping constraints, valid upper bounds and unequal fixed costs. It is not restricted to energy or disjoint totals. Fixed bounded errors also fit by including them in the hidden record, as detailed in Online Resource 1, S6. The finite dictionary matters: allowing every linear functional at equal cost would permit a direct query of the scalar contrast itself.

Computational guarantees have narrower scopes. The general polyhedral formulations handle a declared batch family and exact deterministic two-query planning. The counter rule exploits cumulative sums and a known nonnegative total. The compact coordinate solver uses disjoint exact totals and unit costs. These efficient specializations do not supply an efficient arbitrary-budget precision optimizer for every convex set.

What the application establishes. Two public sources exhibit the same exact feedback-dependent assurance gap. Its prevalence is 5.90% and 1.73%, and overall recorded gains over the best fixed deterministic worst-width batch are only 0.407 and 0.119 percentage points. Greedy adaptation succeeds on all 29 external separation cases. Thus the main benefit is identifying when a guarantee needs feedback, not a large observed improvement over every adaptive heuristic. Three systems per source, repeated model pairs and six-hour blocks do not establish population prevalence.

Illustrative capacity constraints often make feedback unnecessary, while measurement errors can increase the sufficient reading budget. The sensitivity uses exact endpoints and declared internal errors; deployment requires defensible error and physical bounds. The half-initial-width target is a declared precision requirement, not a calibrated financial threshold. A narrow interval can still contain zero. Model ordering, shared retrievals across comparisons, and requests until a decision are separate objectives.

5 Conclusions

The risk objective determines whether feedback can improve the worst-case guarantee for a model-comparison interval. Concavity gives a complete no-improvement classification; nonconcave penalties admit sharp query-based separations. An exact two-query rule and checkable certificates turn that distinction into an acquisition decision. The reference implementation chooses among supplied bulk, fixed and adaptive certificates using declared access and resource limits. New comparisons require new certificates; a catalogue exclusion alone is not an impossibility proof. The public-data results show both when feedback changes assurance and when bulk or fixed retrieval is preferable. The practical contribution is this auditable choice, supported by explicit assumptions and executable evidence.

Supplementary Materials

Online Resource 1, `research_supplement.zip`, contains the editable manuscript, executable methods, frozen forecasts, source identifiers, case ledgers, exact witnesses and numerical checks. Start with `README.txt`; `CURRENT_RESULTS_MAP.txt` maps each current table and verification claim to its command, inputs and outputs. The default verification replays saved forecasts and does not train new models. Separate commands cover raw-input regeneration and fresh fitting. BLEM-derived

traces are reconstructed locally; attributed HeatpumpMonitor records are bundled. The indexed extended methods retain full proofs, solver scaling, historical controls, forecasting protocols and uncertainty checks. Protocol-selection files include all 116 interface decisions and task-bound read-out checks. The separate checker compares saved contrasts with frozen geometry, verifies forecast hashes, and reconstructs retained endpoints from cached API records. Historical reports remain available as clearly distinguished development records.

Additional Information and Declarations

Data and Code Availability

The numerical code and detailed outputs are supplied in Online Resource 1. The public source identifiers are given in the references. The package separates bundled Portugal/household replay from BLEM raw-source regeneration; it does not redistribute the latter's raw counter traces. Constructed polytopes include their complete inequalities and objectives. Dual outputs retain raw multipliers, any numerical mass correction, the completed record, and pricing and enumerated lower bounds. LP and endpoint cross-checks use floating-point arithmetic with explicit tolerances; the counter covering and adverse-profile certificates are additionally checked with exact rational arithmetic on their serialized inputs. No public repository or persistent archived release is claimed.

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The author declares no competing interests.

Author Contributions

Jishan Kapoor defined the research objectives and evaluation requirements, directed and supervised the analysis and revisions, interpreted the findings, and approved the manuscript. The computational and drafting assistance used under this supervision is described below.

Research Transparency

This work uses public data and constructed mathematical instances, with no newly recruited participants. New measurements concern public API response times and payloads, with their small-workload scope reported. Retrospective masks and archive-access assumptions are identified explicitly. Comparisons use the same information and the same stated hard budgets. The new proofs and numerical checks do not change the historical forecast results.

Generative-AI Assistance

Jishan Kapoor provided the topic, set the research objectives and evaluation requirements, directed the analyses and tests, and closely supervised all use of OpenAI Codex (OpenAI; accessed October 2026; model versions were not consistently recorded). The tool assisted with literature searches,

development and checking of research content and code, computational execution, and manuscript drafting and editing. It supported iterative verification and clearer presentation. The author reviewed and revised these outputs and retains full responsibility for the research decisions, interpretation of results, and final manuscript. Separate checker implementations within this study are not external independent replication. This generative assistance is distinct from the boosted-tree and neural forecasting models fitted to the public application data.

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